

Singapore–Cambridge GCE O Level English Language (Syllabus 1184) Paper 2 — Comprehension Practice Paper 27

Time allowed: 1 hour 50 minutes

Total marks for Sections B and C: 45

Instructions to candidates

- Answer **all** questions in Sections B and C.
- The number of marks is given in brackets [] at the end of each question.
- Answer in **complete sentences** where instructed.
- For the summary in Section C, write **no more than 80 words**, not counting the words given to help you begin.

Section B — Text 3 (Narrative) [20 marks]

Text 3: A nurse describes the final hour of a long night shift on a hospital ward.

1

At a quarter past five, the ward had settled into its quietest hour, and I stood for a moment at the nurses' station with both hands flat on the cool counter, willing my legs to remember why they were standing up. The monitors murmured to one another in soft electronic chirps, each on its own small frequency, like a forest of polite birds. Down the corridor, the floor polisher had finished its work hours ago, and the linoleum gleamed faintly in the low blue light. Somewhere behind me, a tap dripped with the unhurried patience of a clock.

2

I had been on my feet since eight the previous evening. My back, which had begun the shift as a back, was now a series of separate aches that argued among themselves about which was the loudest. I drank the last of a cup of tea that had, at some point in the small hours, given up on being warm. It tasted faintly of cardboard and of the long, hollow feeling that arrives, in any nurse worth her uniform, somewhere between four and five in the morning.

3

I picked up the clipboard and began my round. Bed 7 was sleeping with one arm flung above his head, like a boy halfway through a happy dream; I noted the steady rise and fall of his chest and moved on. Bed 9, the elderly lady who had cried, very quietly, when she was first admitted, had finally allowed her face to soften into rest. I straightened her blanket without waking her. There is a tenderness, I have come to know, in caring for sleeping strangers — a tenderness that does not require, and would in fact be embarrassed by, any reply.

4

At Bed 11, the monitor stuttered. The line, which had been pacing along in its quiet green rhythm, gave a small, awkward jump, and then another. I felt my own pulse take a sudden, sharp step forwards. I was already moving — pen down, fingers on his wrist, eyes on the screen — before any conscious instruction

had reached my legs. The years of practice, which had felt so heavy at three in the morning, lifted me forward now as though they weighed nothing at all.

5

The line steadied. The patient stirred, made a small, complaining sound, and turned onto his side. Within half a minute the green trace was once more pacing serenely along its track, indifferent to the small terror it had caused. I stood at his bedside for perhaps a minute longer than I needed to, watching the careful arithmetic of his breathing, and felt the inside of my uniform turn faintly cold where the sweat had bloomed and was now drying. I did not write anything in the notes for several seconds. Then I wrote, in the small, even hand I have used for fifteen years, that observations were satisfactory.

6

By the time I had finished the round, the sky outside the long ward windows had begun to admit, reluctantly, that it was no longer night. A pale, watery grey edged into the corners of the glass. Somewhere on a lower floor a kettle clicked. From the staff lift, I heard the muffled, cheerful voices of the morning team — a sound that, after twelve hours, is more welcome than any music I know. They came in carrying coffee in paper cups, their hair still damp from showers, their faces innocent of everything the night had contained.

7

I gave my handover briskly, professionally, and without drama. I did not mention how Bed 11's monitor had stuttered, except as a single neat sentence on the chart. The morning sister, who had been a nurse longer than I had been alive, glanced at the chart, then at me, and said only, "Well done, love. Off you go." I did not trust myself to answer her.

8

Outside, the air was cold and smelt of wet pavement and of bread from the bakery on the corner. I walked very slowly to the bus stop, my bag heavy on my shoulder, the world looking strangely thin and bright. I thought, as I sometimes do on such mornings, of the sleeping strangers I had just left behind, and of how little they would ever know of the small, watchful hours in which I had stood beside them. It did not matter. It was not, I have come to understand, the kind of work that requires being known.

From Paragraph 1

1. The narrator says the monitors "murmured to one another in soft electronic chirps... like a forest of polite birds." Explain how this image conveys the **atmosphere** of the ward at this hour. [2]

2. Give **two** details from Paragraph 1 that suggest the ward is unusually **still**. [2]

From Paragraph 2

3. The narrator writes that her back "was now a series of separate aches that argued among themselves about which was the loudest." Explain what this language suggests about her physical condition. [2]

4. What does the description of the tea — "tasted faintly of cardboard and of the long, hollow feeling that arrives... between four and five in the morning" — suggest about the narrator's state of mind? [2]

From Paragraph 3

5. The narrator says there is "a tenderness... in caring for sleeping strangers — a tenderness that does not require, and would in fact be embarrassed by, any reply."

(a) Explain, in your own words, what kind of tenderness she means. [1]

(b) Why would this tenderness be "embarrassed by" any reply? [1]

From Paragraph 4

6. The narrator describes how she reacted when Bed 11's monitor stuttered. Explain how the language used in Paragraph 4 conveys both her **fear** and her **training**. Support your answer with **two** details. [3]

From Paragraph 5

7. The writer describes the green line on the monitor as "indifferent to the small terror it had caused." What does the word **indifferent** suggest about the contrast between the machine and the narrator? [2]

8. Why do you think the narrator "did not write anything in the notes for several seconds"? [1]

From Paragraph 6

9. Give **one** piece of evidence from Paragraph 6 that shows the morning team had **not** yet been worn down by work. [1]

From Paragraph 7

10. Why does the narrator give her handover "briskly, professionally, and without drama"? [2]

From Paragraph 8

11. What is the **tone** of the final sentence of the text? [1]

Section C — Text 4 (Non-narrative) [25 marks]**Text 4: A feature article on the hidden economics of online influencers.****1**

To the average teenage viewer, the life of an online influencer looks like a long, sunlit afternoon. A young woman in a linen dress arranges a tray of pastries by a window. A young man, in trainers that retail for more than most monthly salaries, narrates a walk through Tokyo. Behind these glossy surfaces, however, lies an industry whose economics are far more peculiar — and far less generous — than the casual viewer imagines. The work, in fact, is brutal, the income unsteady, and the route to a stable career narrower than that of almost any traditional profession.

2

The income model itself is a patchwork of four uneven streams. The first is sponsorship: a brand pays the influencer to feature a product, usually under contract, and at rates that vary wildly with audience size. The second is affiliate marketing, in which the influencer earns a small commission — often three to ten per cent — when a viewer clicks a personalised link and makes a purchase. The third is the platform payout itself: YouTube, TikTok and Instagram each share a slice of advertising revenue with creators, though the formulas are opaque and the rates per thousand views are modest. The fourth, increasingly, is the “long tail” of merchandise, paid subscriptions, and personal courses — small, slow earnings that may, in time, outlast the influencer’s fashion in the feed.

3

The precarity behind the glossy aesthetic is rarely visible from the outside. A single sponsored post may pay handsomely, but contracts are short, exclusive, and easily withdrawn after a poorly received video. Platforms change their algorithms without warning, halving an influencer’s reach overnight. Income is concentrated, too: a 2023 study by the Influencer Marketing Hub found that the top one per cent of creators earn roughly half of all sponsorship spending, while the median full-time creator earned less than a starting teacher. The smiling face on the screen is, more often than not, the face of a small business owner working sixty hours a week with no sick leave, no pension and no certainty about next month’s rent.

4

In response to this top-heavy market, advertisers have begun to look further down the audience pyramid. The “macro” influencer, with two or three million followers, has been joined — and in many sectors overtaken — by the “micro” influencer (between ten thousand and one hundred thousand followers) and even the “nano” influencer, with as few as one thousand. The reasoning is simple: smaller creators speak to tighter, more loyal communities, and their recommendations are perceived as more genuine. A 2022 industry report calculated that nano-influencers achieve engagement rates roughly seven times higher than those of major celebrities, at a fraction of the cost. The age of the all-conquering household name, it appears, has quietly passed.

5

Regulators have noticed. In the United Kingdom, the Advertising Standards Authority now requires influencers to label any sponsored content clearly, and has named and shamed prominent figures who failed to do so. The United States Federal Trade Commission has issued similar guidance, while the European Union, through its Digital Services Act, has begun to demand greater transparency about the algorithms that decide who is shown to whom. Advertisers, for their part, have grown wary: agencies now routinely audit a creator’s followers for automated accounts before approving a campaign, and brands increasingly write performance clauses into contracts that release them from payment if engagement falls below a stated threshold.

6

The consequences for younger viewers, who form the largest share of the audience, are only beginning to be measured. Studies from the University of Amsterdam and the Royal Society for Public Health have linked heavy consumption of influencer content to increased body dissatisfaction, lowered self-esteem, and a tendency to overestimate one's peers' wealth. Educators report that some teenagers now name "influencer" as a first-choice career — ahead of doctor, engineer, or teacher — apparently unaware of the gruelling labour, the income volatility, or the slim mathematical chance of success. A market that rewards the very few, very visibly, has a way of obscuring the many who do not make it.

7

None of this is to dismiss the work, which can demand genuine creativity and a quick instinct for what audiences want. But the gap between the gleaming surface and the precarious reality has grown wide enough that it deserves to be named openly. The honest answer to the question "Should I become an influencer?" is the same as the honest answer to "Should I become a professional actor?" — that the rewards, for the lucky few, are spectacular, and that for almost everyone else, the path is hard, lonely, and far less photogenic than the feed would suggest.

From Paragraph 1

12. The writer describes the influencer's life as "a long, sunlit afternoon." Explain, in your own words, what this image suggests about how viewers **perceive** the work. [2]

From Paragraph 2

13. According to Paragraph 2, give **two** of the four income streams on which an influencer relies. [2]

14. What does the writer mean when he describes the platform payout formulas as "opaque"? [1]

From Paragraph 3

15. The writer says that "the smiling face on the screen is, more often than not, the face of a small business owner." Explain, in your own words, what this comparison is meant to reveal. [2]

16. Give **two** details from Paragraph 3 that show why an influencer's income is **unstable**. [2]

From Paragraph 4

17. The writer says that "the age of the all-conquering household name... has quietly passed." Explain why this shift has happened, in your own words. [2]

18. What is the effect of the writer's use of the word **quietly** in this sentence? [1]

From Paragraph 5

19. Give **two** actions taken by **regulators or advertisers** to control the influencer industry. [2]

From Paragraph 6

20. The writer says that a market that “rewards the very few, very visibly, has a way of obscuring the many who do not make it.” Explain what this means. [2]

From Paragraph 7

21. The writer compares becoming an influencer to becoming “a professional actor.” Explain why this comparison is **effective**. [2]

22. Summary question [6 marks for content, 7 marks for use of own words and style]

Using your own words as far as possible, summarise **how influencers actually earn their money** and **the difficulties or risks they face in doing so**, as outlined in the text.

Use **only** material from **Paragraphs 2 to 5** of Text 4.

Your summary must be in **continuous writing** (not note form). It must **not** be longer than **80 words** (not counting the words given to help you begin).

Begin your summary as follows:

Online influencers earn their income through ...

— END OF PAPER —